Day 3 — Quality-Count Rule and the Tanmātras

Module: Pañcabhūta (Senior) · **Time:** 45 min

Learning objective

Students explain the *bhūta–tanmātra* pairing and prove the quality-count rule (1, 2, 3, 4, 5 for sky, air, fire, water, earth) is internally consistent given the emergence sequence.

Materials

- Whiteboard
- Printed SB 3.26.36 + 3.26.44 (IAST + translation, from cache)

Flow

Warm-up (5 min)

- Quick recall: enumeration of the five bhūtas with their tanmātras.

Core (25 min)

1. **The quality-count rule** (write boxed):

   Each element inherits all the qualities of the elements that emerged before it, AND adds one new quality of its own — the *tanmātra* associated with that element.

Element	Qualities	Source-verse anchor
ākāśa	śabda	SB 3.26 (qualities-of-space)
vāyu	śabda + sparśa	SB 3.26.36 (directly quoted: “softness, hardness, cold, heat — qualities of touch, tanmātra of air”)
tejas	śabda + sparśa + rūpa	—
ap	śabda + sparśa + rūpa + rasa	—
pṛthvī	śabda + sparśa + rūpa + rasa + gandha	SB 3.26.44 (taste → smell as the last new quality)

2. **Internal consistency:** the scheme is *symmetric and complete*:

   - 5 bhūtas, 5 tanmātras, 5 indriyas of perception.
   - Each bhūta pairs with exactly one tanmātra.
   - Each tanmātra is perceived by exactly one indriya.
   - The quality count (1, 2, 3, 4, 5) is a *predicted consequence* of the emergence order — not an arbitrary stipulation.

3. **Read SB 3.26.36 together** (in IAST): > *“mṛdutvaṁ kaṭhinatvaṁ ca śaityam uṣṇatvam eva ca / etat sparśasya sparśatvaṁ tanmātratvaṁ nabhasvataḥ”* > “Softness, hardness, cold, and heat — these are the qualities of touch (*sparśa*), the subtle attribute (*tanmātra*) of air (*nabhasvat*).”

- Word-by-word with class: *mṛdutvam* = softness, *kaṭhinatvam* = hardness, *śaityam* = cold, *uṣṇatvam* = heat. *etat* = these. *sparśasya sparśatvam* = the touch-ness of touch. *tanmātratvam nabhasvataḥ* = the subtle-essence-ness of air.
- Discussion: notice that *sparśa* (touch) here includes thermal sensations (cold, heat). This is broader than modern English "touch" (which usually means pressure/texture). The framework is more inclusive than we'd assume from a casual reading.

Concept check (10 min)

Worksheet question (1 mark each): - Why does *ākāśa* have only one quality? - Why does *pṛthvī* have five? - What does *sparśa* include that modern English "touch" doesn't? - Why is the bhūta-tanmātra mapping called "one-to-one"? - If a sixth element existed, how many qualities would it have, and what would they be? (Discussion question.)

Wrap-up (5 min)

- Preview Day 4: *"Tomorrow — Empedocles and Aristotle. Greek and Indian elemental schemes side by side."*

Differentiation

- **Tier up:** Write a 1-page response to "if a sixth element existed (e.g. 'information'), where would it sit and what would its tanmātra be?"
- **Tier down:** Focus on the quality-count rule; the bhūta-tanmātra pairing alone is the core skill.

Teacher notes

- The *internal consistency* point matters more than students realise. Many will assume "old framework = primitive." The Sāṅkhya enumeration is *not* primitive — it's tightly self-consistent in a way that the Greek four-element scheme isn't.
- The Empedocles scheme (Day 4) has NO equivalent of the tanmātra-indriya symmetry. That asymmetry is one of the most interesting cross-cultural points in the module.

Citation(s) used

- SB 3.26.36 — vidya-karana RAG cache `day-03-qualities.json#chunks[3]`
- SB 3.26.44 — vidya-karana RAG cache `day-03-qualities.json#chunks[0]`